

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Data-forward briefing for software engineering leads and technology strategists

Methodology & Scope

Updated monthly since 2001 using search-hit volumes across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites.

Tracks discussion and demand signals (engineer interest, training courses, vendor presence), not code quality.

March 2026 editorial reaffirms search-engine methodology over LLM-derived assessments.

Source captured: April 10, 2026.

Headline

Python leads at 21.25%, but posts the largest YoY decline among the top 5. C rises to #2 with the largest gain (+2.02%).

Strategic Use

- Hiring pipeline alignment
- Training investment prioritization
- Tech stack risk concentration checks
- Migration timing signals from momentum shifts

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank 2026	Rank 2025	Language	Rating	YoY
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.32%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	9.79%	+0.09%
4	3	Java	9.31%	-0.46%
5	5	C#	4.87%	-0.87%
6	6	JavaScript	3.46%	-0.25%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.71%	+0.35%
8	8	SQL	2.48%	+0.06%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	PHP	1.74%	-0.11%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	11	MATLAB	1.50%	-0.24%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	17	Assembly	1.30%	+0.24%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	20	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.16%	+0.42%
18	26	Scratch	1.12%	+0.53%
19	19	Ruby	1.09%	+0.03%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

Top-4 Concentration

**Python + C + C++ + Java =
48.97% of the full index.**

Largest Gain

C: +2.02%

Largest Top-5 Drop

Python: -2.59%

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Gainers

Perl

24 → 11

+13

R

16 → 9

+7

Swift

26 → 20

+6

Losers

Go

7 → 16

-9

C++

2 → 3

-1

Java

3 → 4

-1

Rank shift = 2025 position minus 2026 position (positive values indicate upward movement).

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time



Long-Range Signals

- Python: unranked pre-1991 → #1 in 2026
- C: top-2 in every snapshot from 1986 to 2026
- Lisp: #2 in 1986 → #26 in 2026
- Ada: #3 in 1986 → #14 in 2026
- Java peaked at #1 (2001/2006 era) then declined to #4

Interpretation

Ecosystem persistence is high; leadership rotates over decades, not quarters.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2017	C
2016	Go
2015	Java
2014	JavaScript
2013	Transact-SQL
2012	Objective-C
2011	Objective-C
2010	Python
2009	Go
2008	C
2007	Python
2006	Ruby
2005	Java
2004	PHP
2003	C++

Most Wins

Python: 6 total
(2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024)

Recent Pattern

C# won in 2023 and 2025, indicating renewed momentum.

Data Note

2017 winner is not available in the source brief.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Strategic implication: optimize for portfolio balance, not single-language dominance.

1

Python still #1, but monitor decline trajectory

Lead platform language remains valid; hedge with complementary expertise as momentum cools (-2.59 YoY).

2

C resurgence is material, not noise

C gained +2.02 points and climbed to #2; reinforce systems-level staffing and modernization capacity.

3

Legacy ecosystems are reactivating

Perl, R, and Fortran persistence supports selective investment where installed bases are sticky.

4

Go decline raises portfolio-risk questions

Go fell 7→16 (-1.49); review roadmaps where Go is strategic and assess Rust-adjacent alternatives.